

Beyond Rules and Outcomes: Character, Flourishing, and the Doctrine of the Mean

An original lesson plan inspired by **Rosalind Hursthouse & Glen Pettigrove's** the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on *Virtue Ethics*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Rosalind Hursthouse & Glen Pettigrove. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Ethics

“Instead of asking ‘what rule should I follow’ or ‘what outcome should I produce,’ what if the central moral question is ‘what kind of person should I be?’”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Aristotle's concept of eudaimonia (flourishing) and how virtue ethics locates morality in character rather than rules or consequences.
- Apply the doctrine of the mean to identify a virtue as the middle point between two vices of excess and deficiency.
- Evaluate whether virtue ethics can give practical guidance for a real dilemma, compared with consequentialist or rule-based approaches.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard
- Blank doctrine-of-the-mean chart handout (vice of deficiency / virtue / vice of excess)
- Case-study handout describing a workplace or friendship dilemma
- Sticky notes for the virtue-brainstorm activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: What Makes Someone "Good"?

8 min

Ask students to think of someone they consider genuinely admirable and describe, on a sticky note, why — without using the words 'rules' or 'results.' Collect several notes and read them aloud, noting that the answers tend to cluster around traits of character rather than actions or outcomes.

Direct Instruction: Eudaimonia and the Doctrine of the Mean

18 min

Explain virtue ethics' shift in focus from isolated acts to the agent's character. Introduce eudaimonia not as fleeting pleasure but as flourishing — functioning well as a rational, social being over a whole life. Present virtue as a stable, habituated disposition of character, and the doctrine of the mean: a virtue sits between a vice of excess and a vice of deficiency (e.g., courage between recklessness and cowardice, generosity between wastefulness and stinginess).

Small-Group Activity: Mapping the Mean

15 min

In groups, students complete the blank chart for three or four virtues (honesty, ambition, friendliness), identifying the corresponding vice of excess and vice of deficiency for each, and noting one concrete example of behavior at each point on the spectrum.

Whole-Class Case Analysis

13 min

Apply virtue ethics to the assigned dilemma by asking 'what would a person of practical wisdom (phronesis) do here?' and compare that approach to how a strict rule-follower or a consequentialist calculator would approach the same situation.

Closure

6 min

Briefly note virtue ethics' 20th-century revival (via critics like Elizabeth Anscombe) as a reaction against overly rule- or outcome-focused ethics, and raise the 'action-guidance' objection: can 'be virtuous' actually tell you what to do in a hard case?

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is 'what would a virtuous person do' a helpful guide to action, or does it just push the hard question back a step, since we still need to know who counts as virtuous?
- 2 Can virtues conflict with each other in a real situation, such as honesty versus kindness, and if so, how would virtue ethics resolve the conflict?
- 3 Is the doctrine of the mean genuinely useful, or are 'too much' and 'too little' simply defined as whatever isn't virtuous, making the doctrine circular?
- 4 Aristotle thought virtue requires habituation over a lifetime within a supportive community. What does this imply about people raised in difficult or corrupting circumstances?
- 5 How does grounding ethics in character rather than rules or outcomes change how we think about moral education?

Assessment

Students choose one virtue not covered in class (e.g., patience, humility, wit) and write a short paper identifying its corresponding vices of excess and deficiency, applying the doctrine of the mean to a concrete scenario, and explaining what a person of practical wisdom would do differently from someone simply following a rule or



calculating outcomes in that scenario.

Extension Activity

Have students interview an adult they admire about a difficult decision that person made, then analyze the decision through a virtue-ethics lens: which virtues were in tension, and how did practical wisdom, rather than a rule or a calculation, seem to guide the choice?

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